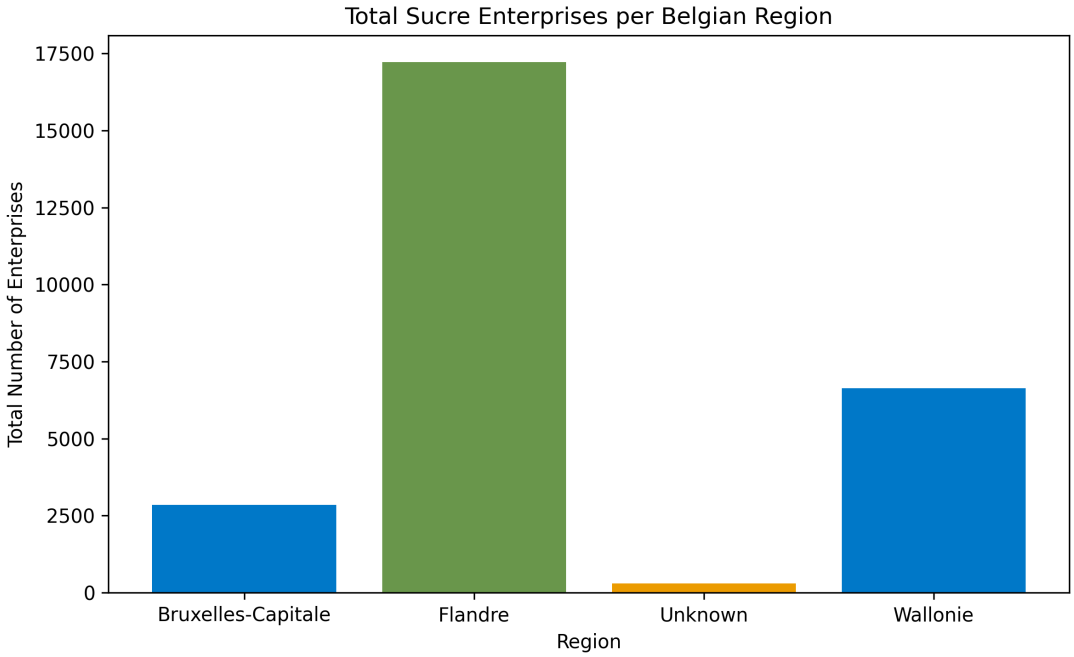
INTRODUCTION

The Belgian economic landscape is shaped by a diverse array of industries, among which the sugar-related sector plays a niche but significant role. With increasing interest in the food and agricultural supply chain, it becomes relevant to assess how businesses involved in sugar production, transformation, and distribution have evolved over time. This analysis focuses on the temporal and regional distribution of such enterprises in Belgium, utilizing data from the KBO (Banque-Carrefour des Entreprises) database and filtered by NACE activity codes related to "sucre" (sugar).

DEVELOPMENT

As part of the data exploration phase, I chose to analyze the geographical distribution of sugar-related enterprises across Belgium. Using a combination of SQL queries and Python-based processing, businesses were filtered by NACE code descriptions containing the word “sucre”, ensuring a focused view on companies directly or indirectly linked to sugar production. The following graph illustrates the regional distribution of these enterprises. Each bar represents the total number of sugar-related businesses per Belgian region, offering insight into regional economic engagement with the sugar sector. This visualization serves as a valuable starting point for understanding how sugar production activity varies geographically and where industrial or commercial clusters may be located.



The chart illustrates the total number of sugar-related enterprises per region, highlighting regional disparities.

- Flandre dominates with the highest enterprise count,
- Wallonie and Bruxelles-Capitale follow with moderate figures,
- An “Unknown” bar reveals unmatched municipalities, pointing to areas for data refinement. This visualization provides a strong foundation for identifying economic

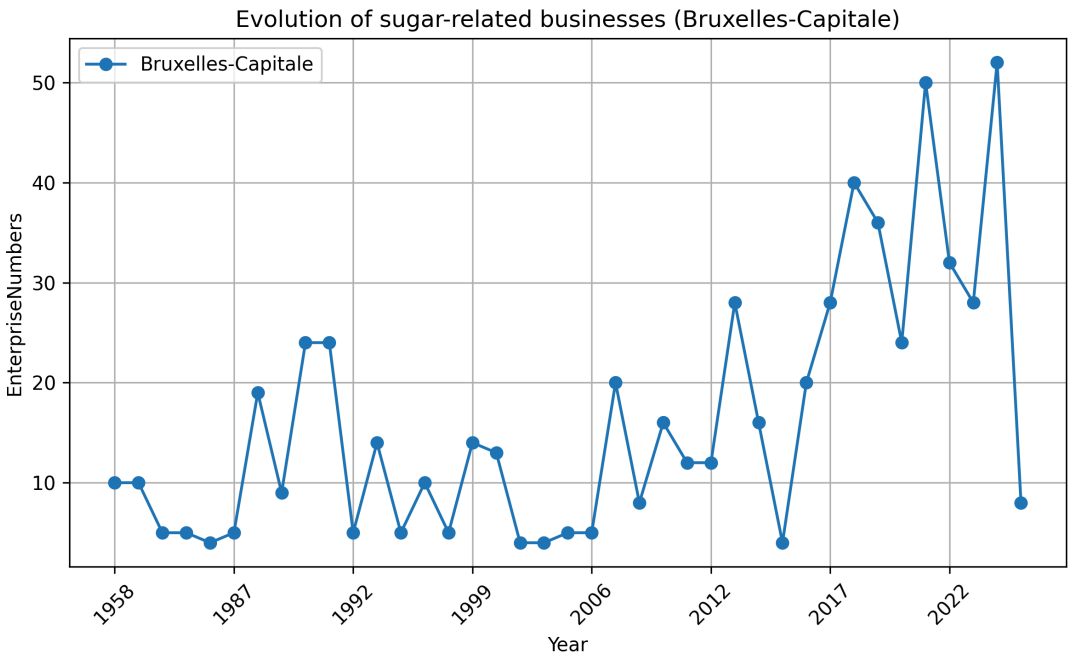
clusters and guiding future policy or investment decisions.

What is that "Unknown" town in Belgium. Let's observe the contains.

MunicipalityFR	NbEntreprises	Region
Breda	16	Unknown
BREDA	15	Unknown
Fontaine-l'Evêque	9	Unknown
mannheim	8	Unknown
ZAANDAM	8	Unknown
PARIS	8	Unknown
Le Controis-en-Sologne	8	Unknown
Köln	8	Unknown
nyon	5	Unknown
Oud-Beyerland	5	Unknown

We observe that several towns listed are actually foreign municipalities. This indicates that certain foreign companies are registered in Belgium, even though their production activities are not located within Belgian territory?

After observed this, we will identify the evolotion of that type of companies in Belgium year by year and by region.

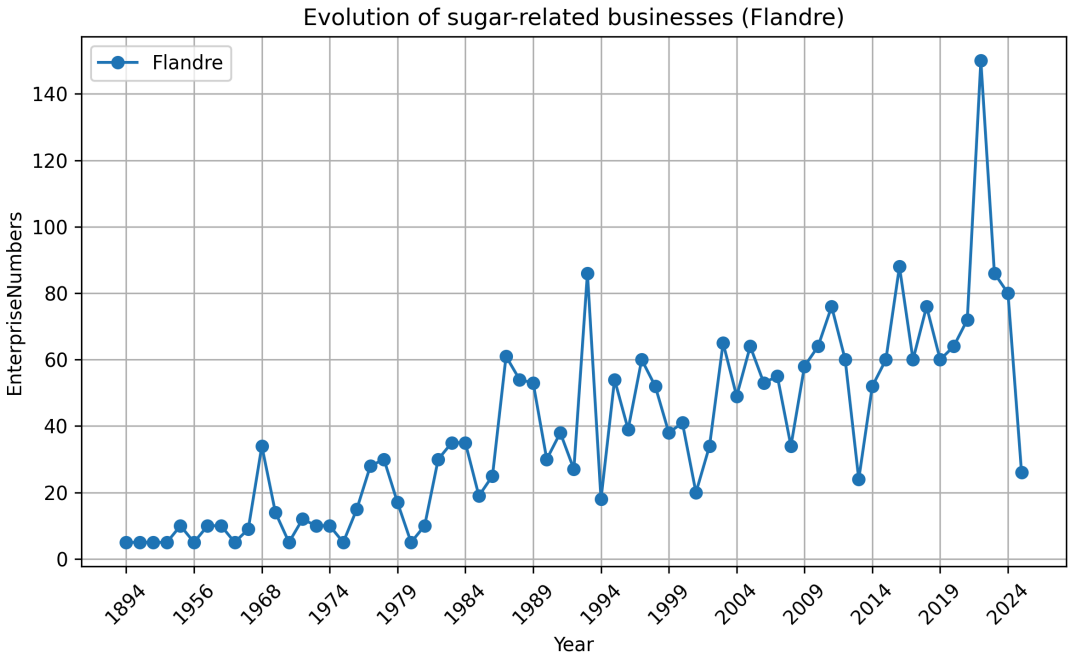


Evolution of Enterprises at Bruxelles-capitale (1958–2025)

- The graph tracks the number of sugar-related enterprises from 1958 to 2025.
- It shows significant shifts in the local sugar industry, suggesting changes in demand, policy, global trends, or business strategies.

  Key Trends:

- 1958–1980s: Relatively low and stable numbers (hovering around 10 businesses). This could reflect a niche industry or limited local production capacity.
- 1990s: A sharp rise to around 20 businesses, indicating growth—possibly due to deregulation, EU market influence, or diversification.
- Mid-2000s: The sector booms, climbing toward 50 businesses, reflecting strong expansion or increased registration of foreign companies?
- 2025: A sharp drop, which might signal market saturation, policy reform, increased competition, or shift away from sugar-focused ventures.

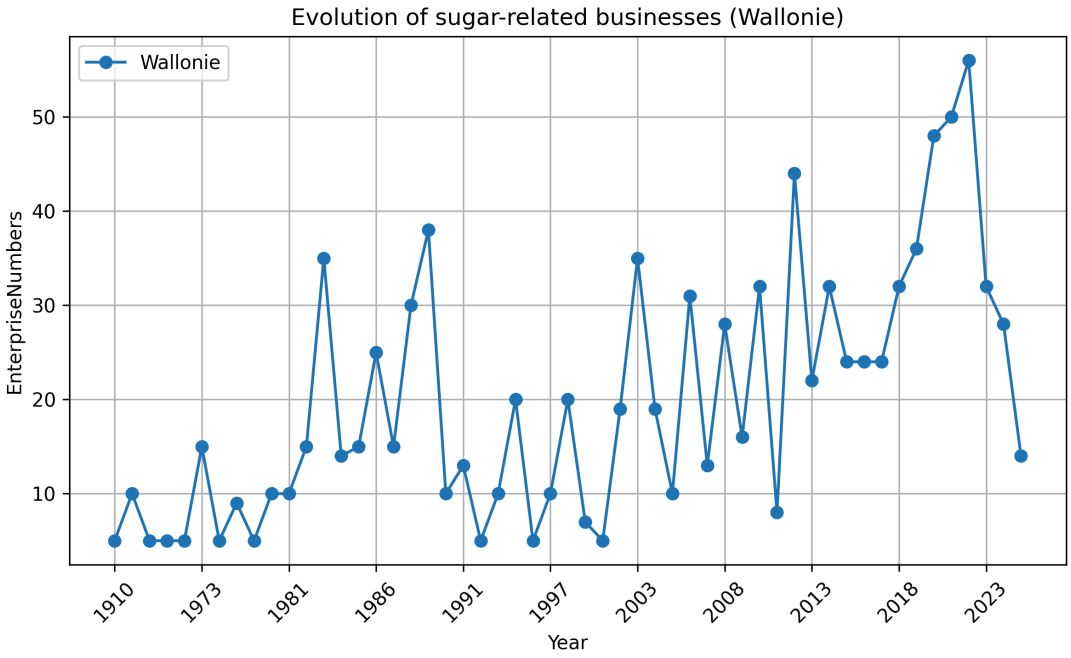


Evolution of Sugar-Related Businesses in Flandre

This line chart visualizes how the number of sugar-related enterprises in the Flandre region of Belgium has evolved over time. The data likely originates from filtered enterprise registrations tied to the word “sucre” in their NACE codes.

Key Observations:

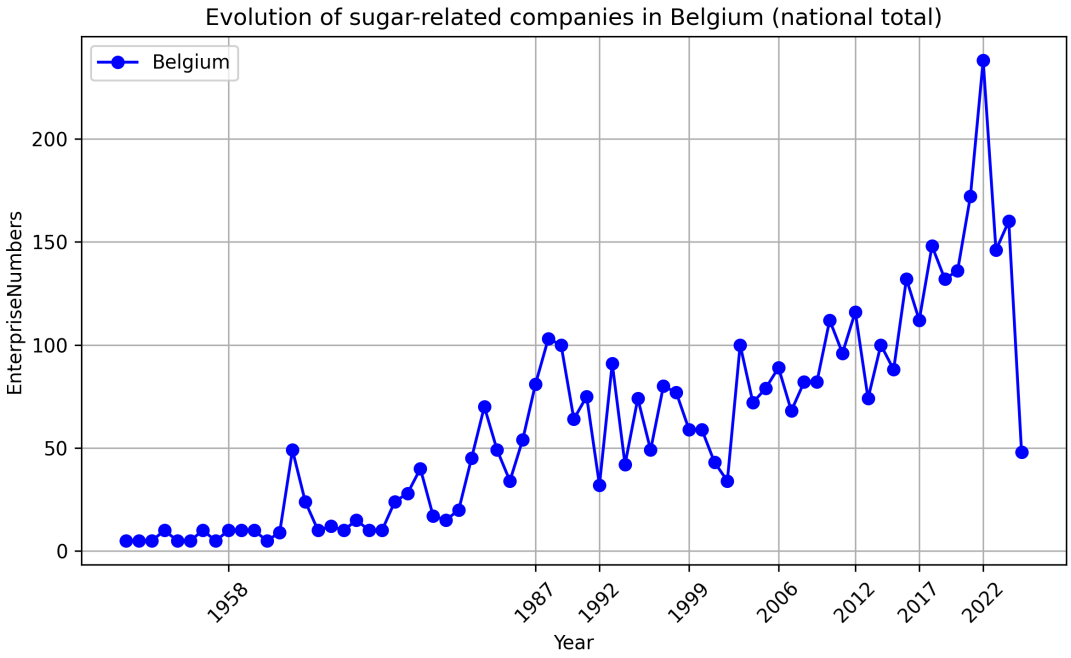
- 1894–1950 : Business activity remained low and flat, with fewer than 10 enterprises — possibly due to limited industrialization or narrower definitions of sugar-related businesses.
- Around 1968 : A noticeable increase suggests expansion in the sector, possibly tied to post-war industrial revival or policy changes encouraging agricultural processing.
- 1990s - 1994s : Another spike, hinting at deregulation, EU market liberalization, or broader sector categorization (e.g., packaging, distribution, substitutes).
- 2024 Peak : The sharp climb toward 140 businesses is striking — likely driven by a mix of:
- Administrative registrations of foreign companies
- Strategic location benefits in Flandre
- Expansion of sugar-adjacent industries (e.g., sweeteners, confectionery, biofuels)



Evolution of Sugar-Related Businesses (Wallonie)
A historical line graph tracing the number of sugar-related companies in Wallonie between 1910 and 2025.

Key Trends :

- 1910–1970: The industry remained small and stable, with fewer than 10 companies. This suggests limited market activity or localized production.
- 1980s onward: A notable rise in registrations, signaling market liberalization, increased consumption, or entry of foreign players.
- 2021 peak: Business numbers climb above 50 enterprises, indicating significant sector expansion—potentially linked to foreign registrations or economic incentives.
- 2025 sharp decline: A sudden drop implies possible policy shifts, market saturation, health regulations, or production relocation.

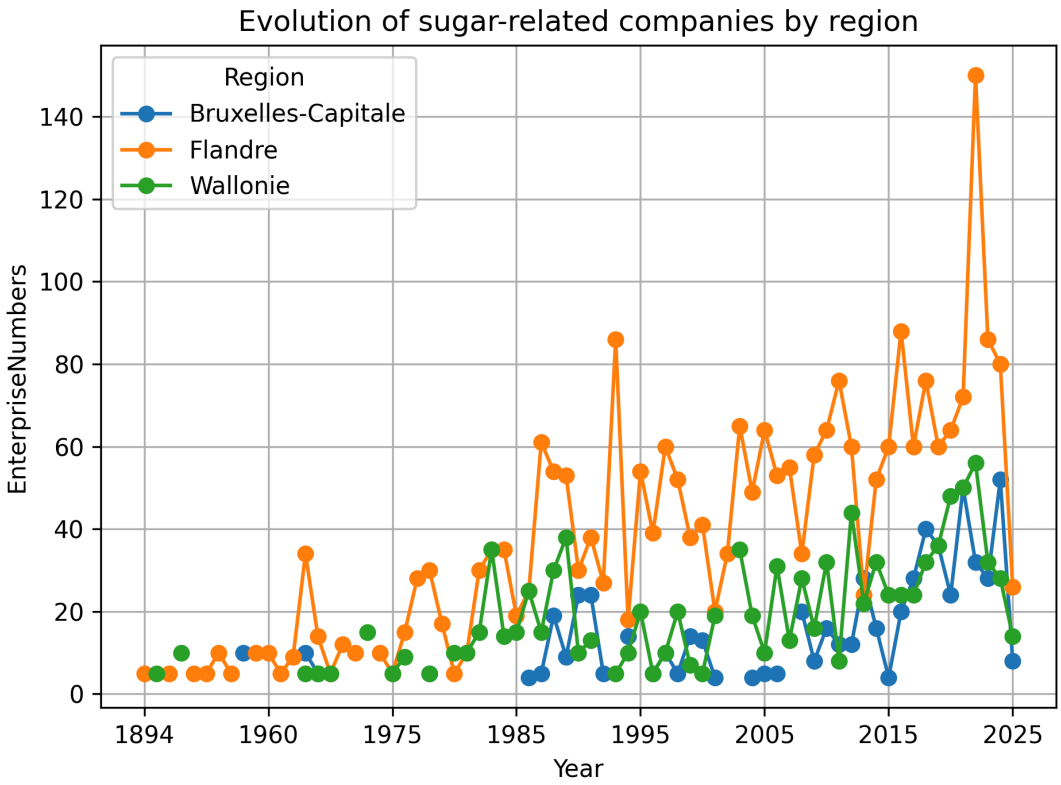


Evolution of Sugar-Related Companies in Belgium

This line graph visualizes how the number of businesses in the sugar sector has changed across the entire country from early 1900s to 2025.

Key Patterns:

- Early stability: From the start up to mid-century, the industry remained modest—around 10 to 30 enterprises—likely reflecting small-scale production or a localized market.
- 1990s–2000s boom: A dramatic climb begins, reaching around 230 companies, indicating explosive growth, likely due to deregulation, EU integration, or increased demand.
- Recent drop: After peaking, there's a noticeable plunge toward 2025, possibly due to:
- Tightened regulations on sugar
- Market saturation
- Shift to alternative sweeteners



Based on the collected data, I created a composite line graph showing the evolution of sugar-related enterprises across Belgium's regions.

Trend Analysis:

- Flandre dominates the sugar enterprise landscape, both historically and in projected data.
- All three regions show a rise in companies post-1980, likely driven by deregulation, globalization, or EU integration.
- The 2025 decline across the board suggests a potential economic shift, policy impact, or market contraction.

CONCLUSION

The data-driven exploration of sugar-related enterprises across Belgium reveals a dynamic landscape shaped by industrial policy, globalization, and shifting consumer trends. Flandre consistently emerges as the epicenter of sugar-linked business activity, likely benefiting from economic incentives. Bruxelles-Capitale and Wallonie follow with more moderate levels of activity, reflecting regional variations in market engagement and economic specialization. The presence of foreign municipalities within the dataset—categorized under "Unknown"—highlights the growing administrative footprint of international entities registering in Belgium, often for logistical or fiscal reasons, but without physical production sites locally. Across time, all three regions show significant growth post-1980, paralleling waves of deregulation and EU integration. However, the recent downturn by 2025 suggests Belgium's sugar sector may be entering a new phase—one marked by market corrections, stricter health and sustainability regulations, and

diversification away from traditional sugar products toward alternatives. This evolving trajectory underscores the need for:

- Further refinement of registry data, especially regarding unmatched municipalities
- Targeted regional policy, to support innovation and sustainable transformation
- Continued monitoring, to anticipate future shifts and maintain economic resilience